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Tom Varner

Tom Varner is a virtuoso of jazz French horn and a composer of cutting-edge compositions. His innovative writing is represented on "Jazz French Horn," "Heaven and Hell," and "Nine Surprises."

Tom was interviewed via Zoom on August 13, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very happy to have Tom Varner with me today. I'm going to prioritize your introduction. I'm going to go with composer first, French hornist and music educator. How's that?

TV: That's fine. And band leader too you did say, or ensemble leader, yeah.

MR: Yeah. I like to start out with a semi-vague question and I'm wondering, in listening to your music and what you've done with the French horn and your approach to your original work, if you consider yourself from an early age to be a pusher of boundaries?

TV: I would probably say yes. Maybe not 9 or 10 years old, but 17 or 18 years old, from then on yes, yes, I would have to say yes.

MR: Did it run in the family?

TV: Not – well my two sisters, I had two big sisters that loved music and loved – had these wonderful record collections from Judy Collins to The Beatles to Eric Dolphy, or the Pentangle, I used to joke about The Pentangle. Very sixties. So I had two big sisters, five years older and two years older, and that set some sparks I think, but they did not become professional musicians, but one is a very fine poet in Western Mass, she's in the Greenfield, Massachusetts area. But from, so not music boundary pushers from my family, but I kind of just fell in love with – I played French horn since I was in the fourth grade. So by the time I was a high school junior I was like I really liked jazz more actually, now that I think about it but well I can't really change instruments now, I'm too old. So I just stuck with it and then when I found out from a next door neighbor about Julius Watkins that helped me realize well then – Julius Watkins who actually went to high school I think with Sheila Jordan, or to the same high school, Cass Technic. But from age say 18 on I was getting that bug for thinking well maybe I could be a jazz improviser on this crazy instrument where now I found out that there were – I didn't know about Jeff Stockham although he's a little bit younger than me but not much. I then found out about John Clark and then I found about David Amram. Hopefully you could do a thousand interviews with them. Willie Ruff. I found out a little bit about John Graas – G-R-A-A-S, you probably know him. And then for a while there that was it. There were a few other, there were studio musicians who could really play in the jazz mode and/or

classical musicians who could play with a great jazz feeling, like Gunther Schuller or like Jimmy Buffington. But people who are real improvisers, there weren't that many at the time when I was say 17 or 18. But it was slowly growing and it dawned on me that – and I was just a very stubborn kid. It was like this is what I want to do, and so I just kept at it.

MR: Did you get the – early on the idea of, I'll call it the typical jazz performance where the head is at the beginning and at the end. And in the middle there's this as long as it goes. But still with structure. Did that dawn on you by yourself or did you have help from a teacher?

TV: Good question. Well I was just listening and listening and listening so much that – but what was unique perhaps for me or my age, those kids that were like in high school in the mid-'70s. I was high school class of '75. We were listening – we weren't doing that thing of like you can't walk until you learn to crawl. A lot of us were listening to Ornette Coleman and Clifford Brown and Charlie Parker and very quickly and Anthony Braxton and Roscoe Mitchell and – so music that would be considered more quote straight ahead jazz and music that was considered quote avant garde jazz and music that was perhaps more structurally post-modern and music that was, like you said, theme, solo-solo-solo, trade, trade fours with the drums, theme, and out. So by the time I was maybe 19 I was already doing a mix of those different approaches.

MR: Did Chick Corea and his electric band or Weather Report have a space in there somewhere?

TV: Yeah I loved that music when I was – and that also kind of turned me on to like wow, I want to do something not necessarily electric like what was that "Return to Forever." I did go see them twice and that was really amazing in the – again – early, mid-'70s. And that was also – structurally it wasn't just boom-boom-solo-solo-over. Chick had much more of a wider compositional outlook one could say. What's interesting is more recently I've been going back and listening to the music from a few years before that, like "Now He Sings, Now He Sobs" which was that incredible trio with Miroslav and Roy Haynes. And that is some very free music. Some of it not, some of it they play standards and then the very next track is like totally free, and then the next track they play "My One and Only Love" on that record. So that was a nice influence on me in that during that time period, now we're talking late-'70s perhaps, I wanted to do all of the approaches at once – or not at once but I wanted to feel proficient in all of those approaches I would say.

MR: Meanwhile to get into the university of your choice did you have the classical horn repertoire under your belt as well?

TV: A little. When I was in high school I was taking some classical French horn lessons with a local guy that was a couple of towns over and who was quite young himself so he was really encouraging and nice and wonderful. And so I did, I just looked at my – I was

opening boxes and trying to throw away – you know about this from moving – throwing away stuff – throwing away stuff, throwing away throwing away. And I opened up a box and there was a program from I think it was May 1975, so that's 50 years plus a couple of months, and it was when I played the movement from the Mozart horn concerto with my high school orchestra. And that was a sweet memory. But that was the pinnacle of my classical career. I played in local – like the South Orange Symphony, and this is we're talking suburban New Jersey. So I was in Millburn, New Jersey, South Orange Symphony, some others in that general area. And I loved it. Those were wonderful experiences. And I loved classical music from say age 14 to 18, a lot. But then I kind of got the bug and I also, when I first – again, Hamilton is a similar place – I first went to – or at least for me – undergrad, first two years, I was at Oberlin College. Now Oberlin has fantastic music but I was in their college, not their conservatory. They are much better now. They are much more, I think freewheeling in terms of what a history major can study music more. So I realized, there was this unspoken rule – well you're a good classical player but you're not really good. Silly, so silly for an 18-year-old. But I also was kind of – by then I'm realizing there is hundreds and thousands of really good, like the kids that might go to Juilliard or Curtis or whatever for classical French horn. There's not, there's like maybe on one hand students out there in the world that really want to be on a high level jazz improvisers on the horn. And I say well this is what I want to do anyway so I might as well just put all my energy into that. So that was kind of my – from age 18 on I was just like boom, that was what I was going to do.

MR: You know our younger daughter played French horn for quite a few years. And I can recall listening to her, you know, when she was starting. And you described the French horn as "slippery."

TV: Yeah. It can be at first especially.

MR: And we listened to her trying to find a pitch, to go up to a pitch and miss, and then finally get it. And my question to you is do you think you were blessed, born with good ears?

TV: I did have good ears, but I did not have a naturally great technique. I was slipping and sliding like everybody else. I did take piano lessons, thank God, with a wonderful lady in Summit, New Jersey, Miss Capitola Dickerson. And she was a fantastic – she was a jazz lover and she was a fantastic just person and teacher, and she told me stories about going to see Billy Taylor on 52nd Street, and she told me about – she'd play me her Art Tatum 78s. And I was a terrible pianist, period. But I loved her, and she just instilled this love of music. And so that helped my ears for sure, the piano. And I had pretty good ears. I could pick out melodies and things on the piano and on the French horn. But the basic classical technique was still not easy. I had to really work at that. And then when you fast forward from age 14, 15 to 18 to translate the technique of the French horn on to being able to

play in that language of Miles Davis or a Clifford Brown or a Charlie Parker on a French horn, that was – required a lot of work. But it was just like kind of slogging work which after a while you kind of get it. You just have to like get through the difficulties of the articulation of how am I going to get this note to go from here to there the way it sounds like a tenor sax imitating Dexter Gordon or something. How the hell am I going to do that? Sometimes you just play, play, play – and you get it.

MR: Is that – I won't even say easier – more possible to pull off by articulating each note more than slurring.

TV: Yes. This is a very good point. In the beginning I sounded very stiff and corny because the only way I could get the notes to come out just right was to tongue every note. So it would be like [scats] I would sound like a '20s band. [scats] even if I'm trying to play bebop. And oh I remember how there was this breakthrough somewhere in the end of freshman or sophomore year, around 19ish, 18ish or 19ish I realized wait a minute. If I can get that phrasing better and not have to tongue every note I will have made a big leap of getting closer to the way we would want it to sound. And I forget whether it was summer of '—maybe summer of '76, summer of '77 – 18, 19 I was able to then finally be able to articulate phrases in a more of a bebop language way that a trumpet might do, or a tenor sax might do, and not have to tongue every note. And that was a big deal. I remember. Then it kind of felt like I was off and running. So I was at Oberlin for two years but I was not in their conservatory and there were so many good things, I made many good friends, some I'm friends with to this day. And bless him, you might have known Wendell Logan. L-O-G-A-N. He was one of the main teachers at Oberlin then. But he was like the one voice in the wilderness kind of. And they were very conservative back then. So I realized I needed a place that was going to be more supportive so I switched over to New England Conservatory. So I had two years at Oberlin, two years at New England Conservatory, and they were very different. They were like, "You want to play jazz on the French horn?" And at first they were like, "What?" And I was like, "Yes!" They were like, "Okay, come on in. Gunther will love this." My first year there it was Gunther's first year not there. Because I think he just wanted to do his own thing. He was tired of being a president. But I was always in touch with him and then I was in touch with maybe you've interviewed or for other projects George Schuller, his son, who is a great drummer and is also a kind of a keeper of the flame of the information of the Lenox jazz school and things that Gunther was up to and a lot of – and "Birth of the Cool" and a lot of those things. So I found a wonderful community then for those next two years.

MR: And you were working with Ran Blake as well?

TV: A little bit with Ran Blake. I first went as a Third Stream major but I realized I got along with Ran a lot better if I was not in his program. Ran– you have to do it his way. Again, bless him, but I wanted to kind of do it my way. So their quote African American music or the jazz program was at that point, for one year only Ernie Wilkins, who was great, Ernie was there, Jackie Byard of course was there, there was a composer/pianist named Tom McKinley who was there. And then the next year Jimmy Guiffre was there, George Russell was there, and then Ran Blake was there. And they were all wonderful and supportive, I must say. They were all pretty, they were like, "You're a crazy kid that wants to play the French horn and be an improviser? Okay. Go for it." They were much more like that.

MR: I'm going to skip ahead a little bit.

TV: Yeah.

MR: In order to make a living, when you established yourself in New York City and during the best years for you what would a week of work entail?

TV: Good question. For some years, many years, even if it was a good week I might have had to do day jobs, just like two or three days a week. Sometimes not. Sometimes – occasionally I did some kind of Broadway show things but not a lot. I was not in the world of the people that did Broadway shows all the time. There was a couple. I did Twyla Tharpe on Broadway, which was a wonderful – John Simon, the guy that had written and conducted for The Band, that guy, he was doing the music and that was a great experience, but that was not a steady type of thing. And I was not in that world of the studio musicians so much. Occasionally I would do something but not on a regular basis like some of the other folks did, like the king of that world was Marvin Stamm. He was the emperor of that world it seemed like at times. But a lot of that dried up in, more like the '90s. '80s it was just amazing. So a little bit of that. So for me a good week would be – if we're skipping ahead now to the '90s, or the late-'80s, I would play at The Knitting Factory, whether it was the old Knitting Factory on Houston or the new one on Leonard Street. I would play in other little clubs with other people's bands. I would play – I'm trying to think where else. Gallery spaces that would have special concerts. Like, kind of like the loft scene, which I had, as a student that summer of '76, '77, I'd go to a lot of those loft concerts which was absolutely wonderful. And through either from that or through making other connections, what for me a lot of that time, a good week would be I would be in Europe. I would be traveling a lot. So I would be meeting people through various connections, going to say Amsterdam and having five, six, seven, eight, nine gigs set up, do them, and come back to New York. And then maybe six months later do it again. Do it again. The other thing that was wonderful was that I – speaking of Sheila Jordan – we both played in the George Gruntz big band. And that provided a nice

– for me, as an extremely low income freelance crazy kid, that provided some income which for me was wonderful. Because we would do a tour – I was trying to think, because I was thinking about Sheila – we did a tour in ’84, in ’83 and ’84, and ’87, and ’88, and maybe one or two more, and then in ’90 or ’91 I did one more that I was invited to, and that was the one that was with Quincy and Miles at Montreux where they combined forces or the George Gruntz band and the Gil Evans, re-formed Gil Evans band with Gil Goldstein. And that was a great experience. But through that time I would network and I would make friends with musicians in Switzerland, in Holland, in Germany, in Austria. So I would then, a lot of back and forth. A lot of like I’d be in New York, I would play with people in Holland. Come home. Be in New York. Go play with people in Switzerland. Go home. And the Swiss groups were often a mix of like one or two Americans, maybe an Italian or a French, and then three Swiss. So it would be this kind of wonderful wacky mix of free improv and written, difficult written music, and jazz, in lots of different configurations over the years.

MR: I wonder if you ever played with Alvin Queen over there?

TV: I remember, I think I met him and I know he was busy in that sort of expatriate world of I guess Switzerland. Maybe he was in Geneva, I forget for sure, or Lausanne. We met but I never played with him.

MR: Now when you go over there and you’re playing with a local rhythm section, I have two questions. Did you carry charts with you, and when you play standards on the French horn do they fall within the range of the instrument? Do you move them?

TV: Sometimes – rarely did I change keys but I might have – often, say in those years in the mid-‘80s if I would go to Europe and play with a new rhythm section I might bring one, an American sax player with me, and/or maybe an American drummer with me and we would play with a local bass player. Or maybe a local bass player and drummer. So it would be a mix of New Yorkers and Amsterdamers. And then we would – I usually did not have a piano, so I didn’t have to worry about telling the piano player how to do this, how to do that. And I would be really inspired by groups that might play standards but with just bass and drums. Like Lee Konitz “Motion” if you know that great record. Or Elvin Jones, it was called “Dear John C” it was a record with Charlie Mariano and Richard Davis. And it was just a trio track. Some of it did have piano in it, but they did this version of “Everything Happens To Me” which I love. I love that tune. So I got my inspiration from Charlie Mariano with Elvin. So we would do that song when I would go to Europe, and I would make it my own and really – so I would pick about two or three standards in addition to my own things that were more perhaps Ornette Coleman-oriented or perhaps modal Coltrane-type influence things, repetitive Steve Lacy type things. So I would do a mix.

MR: Did you find that you play differently without a chordal instrument? And is it necessarily that you play more because you feel like you need to fill the space?

TV: That's a good question. I don't feel like I need to fill the space. You do feel more free, like you might just be very melodic. You might be very quote conservative. You're going to play this old time standard but you can let it sort of like ring out. Think of Sonny Rollins. And he did "We Kiss in a Shadow" on "East Broadway Rundown." He just played that beautiful, beautiful melody and it's just with bass and drums on that particular track, and it's just like ahh. So I kind of like, now we're talking as a 28-year-old as opposed to a 21-year-old, I'm like I want to do that. I want to be – I want to project that sort of like warmth and space and – but there's this mix of abstraction at the same time that Sonny did but with my horn. So I've never worried too much like oh I have to do this because there's no piano or guitar. It was just like I'll play the melody and we'll just solo, and our guide is other great groups that have done it that way. I'm trying to think who else. Well Gerry Mulligan sometimes would have bands where it was just Chet Baker and bass and drums. Or well of course all the great Ornette Coleman groups and then often Steve Lacy. Although in recent years, in the later years he certainly did use piano and he did wonderful duos with Bobby Few, the Cleveland move to Paris, the piano player that he used in his groups. Yeah.

MR: I've had some interesting responses to the question are there wrong notes in improvising.

TV: That's always a good one. Not if you fix it in that phrase [scats] I meant to do that. I do that a lot, especially on the horn, or if it's in the more free improvisational setting I might make a phrase – trying for a certain little phrase but it didn't come out that way, there's like one note that seems sort of quote wrong. So I'll repeat that phrase but with the wrong note, so again it's like I meant to do that. And I'll make a structure out of that in fact little phrase where five notes I quote were thinking that's what I wanted, and then the sixth note in there somewhere is not. And I'd go okay, that's what it's going to be. I'll do that.

MR: I had a couple quotes here about free improv. And I wanted to share them with you, see if you have a reaction. The first one is from Karl Berger, who said to me, "More freedom is not about less precision, it's about more precision. I'm creating my own rules and they're much more stringent." And Anthony Braxton, who I have not interviewed but I read this, he said, "I was never interested in runaway improvisation."

TV: I understand that quite well. I like to have, if it's quote unquote free improvisation, whatever that means – I like to have the settings where it's still I don't want to say controlled like but I kind of am controlling it as a composer setting up a certain structure or guidelines for in the moment in which if I'm recording a series of improvisations they might be pretty short. So right there I might have, especially on the new things that I just did recently when I got a sabbatical and I was on the East Coast and I met with lots of

dear old friends and many new friends, and we would – we recorded many two-minute tracks. They were free but they were lots of little miniatures. And then the end product I would, with my decisions, put them together in interesting sequences basically. But when something is only two minutes you really just grab on to one or two ideas and let it be. If you want something to be totally free but 15, 18, 20 minutes, you better have, as Karl kind of was saying, and/or Braxton, some serious ideas up in your sleeve that you would be able to use. But you don't want to just – but not as tricks. This is the thing. It's a fine line. You don't want to use them as little tricks but you don't want to meander at the same time, like where do we go now, where do we go now. And so the mark of a really good improviser is like they're able to make a statement with great intention. Make something with that. And then maybe at a certain point change. And when it's two or three or four musicians and they change all at once it's a wonderful moment when that happens I guess. So I like Karl's quote in that in some ways it's harder 'cause you don't have the safety of like okay as long as I play these chord changes within this time framework of "All the Things You Are" or whatever the tune it is, I won't fail. It might not be great but it won't be terrible. But if you're playing very free and it's a situation where you're not relying on that it could be really good. But sometimes it could be pretty bad. It's a little bit more of a tightrope one could say.

MR: And what sounds acceptable to the person playing it may be different from with an audience person hears.

TV: That is true. Sometimes the musician is like zeroing in maybe with another improviser together on some very specific strange little molecular grainy sound and you're like, "Oh I like that" and you just want to stay there. Like zeroing in like the microscope. And certain listeners would be like, "Wow, oh that's so great." But other people are like, "Oh my God they're playing the same weird little sound. But that's just the nature of the beast. I don't know if you know the great British improviser Evan Parker. He will zero in on – well he'll do duos, he used to do duos with Anthony Braxton and they might zero in on some one little sound and just stay there, or with circular breathing, or the overtones. Well you know as a saxophone, the overtones you could get and the harmonics and just stay in that one little place. So some people love it, some people like ahh.

MR: You know Roscoe Mitchell, who I had a session with –

TV: Exactly. He's a good example of that.

MR: Yeah. He got an NEA I think recently and the little promotional video with him and it showed him with I think it was like a sopranino sax or something. And he's just going [scats]. And I tried to have an open mind, and that's him I guess.

TV: Well he loved his long tones. And I know in other situations where he was going to play like a solo concert – who was – my friend Wayne Horvitz wrote a story about it and he

came early and before the concert started, to warm up, he just played one long tone for an hour. Just like zeroing in, zeroing in. So I always loved that about Roscoe. But it's true. That's a good example of the extreme – what's the word – there's another word for zeroing in on it but I've lost my –

MR: Focus I suppose.

TV: Yeah. Extreme focus on one small thing kind of. I loved – when I was – only those two years at New England Conservatory I did have a write a paper and I wrote a paper on Roscoe. And I wish I could find it. There was – oh you might have it in your archives. There was an article on Roscoe in the Canadian *Coda* magazine. That guy named Bill Smith, not the clarinet player but the writer. And the end of this quote from Roscoe was like he said, "I just want to make sounds that are as natural as the way these ducks over here are quacking in this pond." And I loved that quote. He said that's what I want to do. Those ducks aren't worrying about whether it's right or wrong, they're just quacking. And if I could find that quote – it's hard to find those *Coda* magazines.

MR: Yes.

TV: You might have it somewhere in the – but it's probably in the library at Hamilton.

MR: Yeah.

TV: A lot of places have *DownBeats* and that's about it. A lot of that stuff is – but there's a lot of people – you're probably in touch with Loren Schoenberg.

MR: Yes I am.

TV: He, I bet he's one. He can find – if anybody can find it he can.

MR: Or Phil Schaap but he's gone.

TV: Yeah, yeah. My old buddy who wrote a book on Lester Young, and wrote a book on Coltrane – Lewis Porter. He could find that I bet.

MR: I want to hone in a little bit – when you were talking about your sabbatical and being on the East Coast, the shorter compositions, was this made into "Heaven and Hell"?

TV: That was a little earlier. "Heaven and Hell" was from when I moved to – well I moved – so I'll make it really quick. All those various things I was doing, that was in New York, go to Europe, back and forth, go blah-blah-blah. Then I got married, then I had kids, then I had two kids. And trying to get the two kids on the subway etcetera, etcetera. My wife was a Seattle native. I'd been in Manhattan for 24, 25 years and so we were like okay, and I had friends that had moved to Seattle, let's make that move. It'll be just better in many ways, especially for our kids and our lives, etcetera, etcetera. And it was. It's been great. But then I had this idea for making a larger project, not a quintet, not a septet, but more like a tentet – nonet, tentet, where I could work with those ideas a little bit more. So that was a group of Seattle musicians plus the great trumpet player Russ Johnson who is now in the Milwaukee area. So some of those pieces were miniatures, that's true. But

some of them were much more longer, thought out, composed. I was very fortunate in that a couple years earlier I was able to go to have a residency at the McDowell Colony. Oh that was heaven. Just wonderful. And a lot of the music for "Heaven and Hell" I wrote for that type of configuration. I had to adjust the instrumentation a bit. So but that was a mix of notated compositions with improv and then short takes that were really just like little 60-second meditations kind of. So later, now fast forward to another ten years, or even more – no not – yeah, something like that, I've been teaching at Cornish College of the Arts where many great people have been there and taught – Julian Priester had been there, Gary Peacock had taught there. Anyway I've been there for 15 years. I was very fortunate in that I was awarded a sabbatical. But I thought okay, I'm going to go back to Brooklyn and New York and Boston and Upstate New York and meet with lots of people who are near and dear to me, and just set up little – now you can get higher quality, quick set-up recording devices. So I did. I recorded 110 takes. I went a little crazy. And lots of those were very short, one to two to three minute improvisations. But I knew that all of these people were totally capable. Knew exactly what to do. I barely had to say a word. I would do something like with the great trumpet player Steven Bernstein and the trombone player Joe Fiedler. We did a brass trio. I'd say, "Okay Joe and Steven, Joe and I are pretending that we're a bluegrass banjo. Steven, you're the singer but with your slide trumpet. Okay? This is going to be the tempo." That's it. And they'd go, "Got it." So we did. And that's like maybe one of the first takes of that day. So a lot of things of those literally 110 tracks of lots of different – there was – I did eleven sessions. A lot of them were these little two-minute miniatures basically. With no written music. Nothing more than my verbal, "Let's try this, let's try that." Sorry.

MR: Was "Waltz for the Proud Tired Warriors" one of those?

TV: That was written at McDowell. That was part of "Heaven and Hell." That was more hard to describe. There was a sequence of chords in the 4-bar or 6-bar modules that kept changing. I think I was reading something about the composer Arvo Part. And he was taking these phrases and going up a third, down a major third. Up a minor third, down a major third, up a minor – so I just said hey, I could take this little cell that I wrote and do it with that but have an alto sax solo over the whole thing. So that was that part.

MR: And the alto sax player, how do I put this – have a chart? Did he know?

TV: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

TV: Yeah. That music had very specific – we all had parts. So I would go [scats] and then the trumpet [scats]. That was very written out. And then the changes I gave to the alto sax. He had nothing written to actually play though. He just soloed over the whole thing. Like, kind of like Lee Konitz might, or, he had studied, there's a guy named Mark Taylor but

not the French horn player Mark Taylor. There's lots of Mark Taylors. There's a fantastic alto player named Mark Taylor in Seattle who had studied with Dick Oatts, the great sax player, and he had some of that approach in there too. But he did have a set of changes but only a set of changes for that particular piece. There were other tracks on that that were just little meditations. And then the other ones were much more big, thick, massive like Messiaen crazy chords, very fat parallel motion of like everybody has their own, like eight different notes, the last track on that.

MR: Speaking of that, parallel notes, "Choppy and Dumb"?

TV: Oh yeah. That one --

MR: Because I just – I was going to the piano and I said okay, there's one note here that sustains and then there's this – I couldn't figure out the interval.

TV: That's great. Good listening. I wanted something literally to be like the sort of feeling of kind of like dread. Basically a lot of that's about looking back a few years at 9/11, New York City. And not that particular track, but some of them were. And oh my God we have kids now, and we're getting ready to have this beautiful new baby boy, and now 9/11 has just hit New York City so that "Choppy and Dumb" wasn't literally trying to be that but I wanted these low notes just to be like [scats]. I don't know if I even gave them specific pitches. That's why you couldn't figure it out. I just think I told them, "Play any low note and just hold it." And then – it was a sax quartet. I think I had the sax quartet play – that was written out – [scats]. And they nailed it. They said, "Do you want us to play it like really dumb? Like stupid?" [scats]. "No problem, we can do that."

MR: It almost struck me like, "All right, play with a junior high tone here."

TV: Yeah. I actually wanted that. So when they did it they were like, "Are you sure?" And I was like, "Yes, I love that, that's what I wanted."

MR: Would you be, if you played that piece in a live situation, would you be offended if people found it to be humorous and started laughing?

TV: No. That would be totally fine. I would not be – I would love it if it made them laugh, I would love that. I don't have a problem with people – if they laugh just 'cause they think that's a stupid sound maybe I wouldn't like that. But if they laughed because they're like, "This music has some kind of humor to it and I like that" then great. I'm happy. Yeah. Because a lot of my music does have some humor.

MR: At what point do you assign a title to your work?

TV: Sometimes that's hard, especially all these crazy miniatures of the last fall. It's only on Band Camp so I'll be happy to send you codes for those more recent ones. But sometimes it's after the fact. I'll listen and I'll go, "Okay this should be the title for this – this should be the title for that." Sometimes I'm really working on the piece if it's more of a written music piece, I'm on the piano and I'm sweating it out, I will already know the title. I

think it just depends on the situation. If it's very much a free improv usually the title comes afterwards. I'm trying to think, what about – yeah, something like that.

MR: Well I wanted to ask about this tune, "What is This Thing Called First Strike Capacity"?

TV: Right. Capability.

MR: Capability.

TV: Well if you remember the Reagan era, Reagan and Brezhnev doesn't seem like so different again. I knew that my alto sax player at that time named Ed Jackson loved to play over the changes of "What is This Thing Called Love." And I wanted to write – that's what it is, I wanted to write something more along the lines of like Tristano might write over that, like a "Subconscious-Lee" basically. And so I just wrote this crazy line on "What is This Thing Called Love" and then I realized oh I want the first entire chorus to be just walking bass, then these little hits, then the actual crazy, notey melody, then the hits, and then over and out. And so afterwards I think I thought sort of the doomsday humor, Stanley Kubrick humor I guess. And that came right to it.

MR: That's good, Stanley Kubrick humor, yeah. Do you have a sense of what you hope listeners get from your music? I asked this question to Ran Blake and he said, "As long as I don't bore the listener I'm somewhat happy."

TV: That's good.

MR: I'm thinking what your music, at least the ones I've heard is adventurous, and what do you hope people get out of it?

TV: Well even if it's humor, I still want to make some kind of an emotional human connection I would say. But if they like it as a purely sound experience, sound textural sound and liking it purely for that – the interesting textures of the sound that they're listening to – that's fine as well. But for me, if I'm hearing something like that, even if it's like two improvisers playing just like one note with like interesting overtones etcetera, etcetera – to me that can be very emotional. I might be kind of weird in that way, so it doesn't have to necessarily be a beautiful melody. Although I love beautiful melodies. I love the beautiful melodies of like Ornette Coleman, like "Lonely Woman" or something like that. Or I'm trying to think what else – I don't know. So if it affects them one way or another I'll be happy. Hopefully it won't annoy them so much that they're gritting their teeth. But I think that's usually not the case. I think usually whether it's some kind of emotional connections or humor or both, or the sort of enjoyment, almost like sensual enjoyment of the sound itself, I love the idea of that as well. Like Sonny Rollins just playing that one note in the mid to late-'50s.

MR: One thing that I think is wonderful about your tunes is that when you write unison lines with the horn, whether it's with alto or tenor sax – they sound so different from if you

were playing the trumpet. We're so used to that trumpet-sax – you know, all through bebop – and the tone quality of the horn just makes it like a new thing.

TV: Yeah. Yeah. It's true. I used to talk about that with the arranger/composer Jim McNeely, that he would say, "The horn is kind of like this glue. If it's a larger ensemble and there's a horn inside there you might not hear, like, 'Oh there's a French horn in there.' But if you take away the horn you're going, 'Oh that's totally different.'" It provides this – well he used the word "glue" between the different instruments. And it's true. The overtones of the sax and the overtones of the French horn are such that when they're together it's very different from trumpet and sax, or two saxes or two horns for that matter. So I've always loved that.

MR: Some of those tougher lines that you've written I almost wondered like you were writing them knowing that a really good sax player could play them, and then you almost forgot that you had to play it too.

TV: Yeah. You got it. That's true sometimes. Or you could play it when you're 28 and then you're going to revisit it when you're 58 and you're like what was I thinking – how am I going to play that? And that one called "What is This Thing Called First Strike Capability" on this sabbatical, it was wonderful. I met up with Ed Jackson, the alto player again, and we played in this club that he has a small kind of informal club which is wonderful near Elmont in Queens, Jamaica Queens. And we played that tune and I was like whoa, we got together and we both had to practice that one again. And he also was saying there's a section in the bridge [scats] it's the worst because it's the pinky. As an alto sax player you have to do this pinky. I didn't know. For me, that part of it was actually easy. And all sax players were like, "Why did you pick those three notes?" Sorry. I'll let the sax players do a little work on that one.

MR: Really. They've got all those keys. It should be easy.

TV: Yeah. Yeah. Exactly.

MR: It's something I came across today made me think that next January 6 will be the fifth anniversary of the attack on Congress. And I don't know why my mind went – because I was listening to your music and I was thinking if someone commissioned you to write a work to mark that anniversary, would you accept it, and where would you start?

TV: Oh boy. Wow. I think I would accept it but it would be a difficult job. It would be a lot of I don't know what it would come out sounding like. Irony? Like Shostakovich type mocking of stupidity you know? Mingus? Like "Fables of Faubus." That's the first thing that comes to mind. Shostakovich making fun of the Stalin ass-kissing generals and Mingus making fun of the horrible racist governors at the time. There'd be plenty you could come up with between – I'm trying to think who or what else? But that's plenty. Shostakovich and Mingus. I think that's the first two names that come to mind, and I

would like, maybe I'd be off and running. But it would be a difficult job, also depending on how –

MR: Who you could get –

TV: Who I could get but also the political climate even from now to coming up in January 6, what's going to happen in the midterms etcetera, etcetera. Will we feel a little bit more hopeful or will we all be ready to jump off a bridge. Don't know. But I would take the challenge in any case, for sure.

MR: Do you ever get away from your music room, your piano, your horn, and just walk and work on ideas? Even not on purpose.

TV: Yeah. Yeah. I have been doing that a little bit more. It's been hard to like (a) teach in college full time; (b) teach in college full time then with the Covid days and that really took a lot to just keep your spirits up to then be super creative in the middle of all of that. Some people have been. My hat is off to them. A lot of my friends, I don't know if you know the flute player/composer Jamie Baum. She's somebody you might want to interview. She has this great record out that's based on sort of modern American poetry but it's with this sort of octet and there's you know Adrienne Rich or somebody else, but with great players. But she was stuck in Manhattan in a high rise, sometimes didn't get out for weeks. It was horrible. So she's like, "All right, I got to do something." So she wrote this beautiful suite of pieces. But she was not teaching full time and she didn't have kids. But she made great use of that time in that way. But once Covid was over, and I'm trying to think, then I got back to teaching more in person, which was great. But it's just been hard to have the bandwidth and the brain power to like work on these big ideas. But I could do a lot of shorter improv-oriented pieces. And then I got the sabbatical and that's been wonderful. But now I've retired. Now I do, I feel like okay I – so if I'm walking outside with no headphones, no music, no nothing, no agenda, I'm like saying okay, okay, if I have three saxes and three brass and I would have them do this and I could have them do this – more along the lines of "Heaven and Hell." Or the other one called "Nine Surprises," which is kind of like "Heaven and Hell Part 2" a little bit more optimistic, not quite so dark. So now I am starting to do that, and I need to, starting like today, get to that more. I'm like, well you might be finding out too – you're not completely retired because you're doing this job as a half-time job. But still if you have more free time on your hands you're like okay now I can utilize the bandwidth that is now just freed up to do some of these other things, and I really do want to. Yeah.

MR: Okay. I'm going to wrap up with one and a half questions. Did you teach long enough that you noticed, with the students, a change in what they brought as freshmen. I guess I'm sort of leaning towards the technology question. How did it affect – did you see an

effect of the ever-changing technology in the outlook and the general education that students came to you with?

TV: Yeah. I would say very much so, yes. Ten years ago, twelve years ago, the students that were coming as first year students might have played in band much more, might have played guitars and played real instruments much more. They didn't necessarily know about computers but they could play instruments and they knew basic music theory. Not all, but many. Fast forward to four years ago, five years ago or three years ago, many had never played in a band but they had very good ears. They were good with computers and they could do their Abelton or their logic music on their computers but they didn't really understand music theory very well. They knew how to program, but not say okay I've decided that this is going to be a C 7 sharp 11 type of a thing. And so I had to teach – I had to fill in those gaps at times. But creatively what's been wonderful is even though the numbers have shrunk and of the actual number of students that are wanting to come and do music, the ones that did come within those four years from year one to year four, some are coming up with wonderful, great, wild, crazy, creative ideas. And that makes me really happy. The creativity just keeps going and going. And a lot of them of course are – well any kid would be better than me at technology. I'm learning my – I can do little things. I have my Abelton, I have my Finale but they are much more – adapt and fast with technology in general. I just wish more of them – well I wish they had opportunities to play more and I wish – well Cornish is a special case because it's changed much more to singer/songwriters and we might only have like two trumpets, two sax players, they might be really good and really creative but it's not like an Eastman or a New England Conservatory or a University of Washington where there's going to be enough people to really be in a big band etcetera. So I felt bad for the kids that were stuck in high school their junior and senior years in their bedroom during Covid. That was really, really rough. And you might have – at Hamilton met some that were – oh yeah, this is the first time I'm in a class now.

MR: Very odd. Okay. My half a question: do you think it was odd that Stan Kenton used mellophones instead of French horns?

TV: I think – I never thought about it much one way or the other, but I think he wanted that direct sound. He didn't want the more non-directional. Because the thing with the horn, it's true if there's a big band and there's even a couple of horns if it's soft it'll work. Like Claude Thornhill. But if it's brassy and loud and trumpets and loud trombones and if he wanted that extra thing the mellophones I guess make more sense.

MR: I think you nailed it.

TV: The directional.

MR: The direction. Because he wasn't usually, he wasn't after subtlety.

TV: No. Do you know the famous line from the great – oh God now I can't say his name. There was as great lead trumpet player – Al Porcino.

MR: Oh yes. That's right. I've heard this story. Yes.

TV: He was on the bus and he says, "Fellas, I think tonight we're going to do something we've never done before." And Al Porcino said, "You mean swing, Stan? Swing?" Oh he was a character. I met him on one of those George Gruntz tours. He came and said hi to everybody. And even then he was dark. He said, "Yeah I play these gigs in German big bands" he said, "it's a wasteland." He was very dark. But you know what? There's another saying about – joke about music. How do you make a musician complain? Give him a gig.

MR: Good one.

TV: That was Al Porcino in the late '80s probably.

MR: Yes. Eddie Bert was on the band and he said there was one gig where they were really crowded on the stage, incredibly crowded. And for some reason because of that it felt great and they started swinging. And Stan stopped the band and said, "This is not Count Basie."

TV: Oh. Terrible. Terrible. Which reminds me of, okay one more, and then we've both got to go. Glen Ferris, who is a fantastic trombone player that had played with both Frank Zappa and Harry James, which is hard to imagine, and he's been in Paris for many years and played with everybody. But when he would really get into a solo he would just move and move and swing, he just couldn't help it. And at one point Harry James told the lead trombone player or the trumpet player, it's like, "That kid is pretty good but tell him to stop conducting the band."

MR: We could go on and on, couldn't we?

TV: Oh yeah. All right.

MR: All right.

TV: I'm happy to send you more. I could send you pages and pages of more, or links if you'd like. I'll send you some of the links, the Band Camp, the more recent, the miniatures, basically those records from the trip. Yes.

MR: Excellent. I'd enjoy that. Thank you.

TV: Thank you for doing what you do. I really appreciate it.

MR: That's nice to hear.

TV: Yes. Okay.

MR: I'll just stop this and we'll say our good-byes.

TV: Okay.